

Chapter 2

Good Morning!

The nightmares showed no sign of stopping, I would wake up every morning in a cold sweat with the sensation that I had somehow momentarily caught myself mid fall from atop a tall building and was now falling again, nothing to hold onto and I didn't have a reason to stop. Then I would remember her, it would pull me out of my thoughts for just long enough to stumble toward the nightstand, pick up my phone and text her,

Hey

She hates when I say Good Morning, believes it makes the morning worse, I would call it superstition but I've seen it get close to being true enough times that for the sake of both of our comfort, hey is better. Of course, that isn't the only reason, saying that word is our thing, something I only say to her and nobody else, it makes her feel more special to me than anyone else and I love it.

I start sinking again, feels like I'm on the terrace of that building, I'm looking down off it's side, I don't want to jump, but the wind, it's so strong and it's blowing me towards the edge, for a moment I entertain the thought of it being easier to fall down. Honestly? I was tired of this balancing act between school exams and Jee, one of the supposedly toughest exams in the world that they were preparing us for as if it's just another normal thing to crack that any aspirational student could do with their eyes closed if they just memorized the right stuff. The marks I was getting in the monthly tests were fine, my mom however made it sound like I was doing horribly

and was a failure and well the only thing it made me think was

You should jump off that building right now!

Which uh, again, I kind of wanted to listen to. I guess this is the reason I tried to make inside jokes or find unique things to do or say to people I liked, people who I wanted to ensure had a special place in my life. I didn't trust myself and thought I would forget them and therefore tried as many things as I could to prevent that from ever happening.

Which brings me to the point of my story where I tell you what exactly pushed me this far. Apu was the only person in my life who I trusted completely. There are few people I could give my life for and be glad that I did and she is one of them. Lately I had been blaming myself for not doing enough to help with her depression and thought it was my fault and everytime she would blame herself for something or have an episode, I would subsequently blame myself and have a panic attack. Eventually it got worse, as I thought she seemed happier when she hung out with my other friends, or when I wasn't around to constantly annoy her with my questions that seemed more like a forced interrogation of forcing her to feel something and forcing a fake laugh or smile just to satisfy myself. I thought I was the problem and me not being there would be the solution to all this. I wouldn't have to fail at living life and she wouldn't have me to remind her that she is depressed and needs to be better.

I texted Prajakta every morning. Her presence in my life is normal. A shift away from these complex emotions that I had still not decided if I loved or

hated. I liked her company and she did mine, she made me feel wanted again and this friendship was something I was good at, it was not an uphill battle like everything else before but a slow car ride across the countryside that helped me run away from the harsh bubble of reality that I had shut myself in. I told her how panic attacks work and how they affect my life, how scared they make me and how I am in a constant state of worthlessness and borderline being suicidal.

She is a good listener, even when she didn't know how to respond or what to do, she listened and didn't judge, she understood what I was saying so perfectly and telling her about myself was easy. I felt safe for the first time in a month. This brings me back to my point of trying to build something with her that was more than just me being an acquaintance, I wanted things unique to us that only we did. We gave each other nicknames, and would react with a handwave emoji each time we told each other bye, she didn't like saying goodnight either.

She showed me that I could trust her, which I still to this day don't understand how. But she was caring, more care than I deserved at that time from a person I had just started speaking to and would always be there for me when I had an attack. It felt like she was saving me from certain death each time she held my hand and pulled me out of my mess, I eventually told her things that I couldn't tell Apu. I had stopped talking to Apu about my feelings because these days feelings about her situation were the reason for my attacks and I didn't want to push her away for her concern for my own good.

The moment came about a week after we started talking when I told Prajakta for the first time how I really felt. I was scared, Apu had opened a closet in my mind that was filled with feelings I used to consider insignificant and stupid. She taught me how to talk about them and how to deal with them. The reality was that at the time, I needed her help to process these feelings. And with her current state, and my reservations about what I should or should not tell her, that was becoming impossible and I didn't wanna go back in my shell at all. I expected judgement from Prajakta. Expected her to call me stupid and weird, she didn't, she listened and comforted me. She stood by my side, and held me when I didn't know where I was going or what to do.

In my sadness, I cried myself to sleep every night for the past month. But the evening I texted her, I cried because I found solid ground, I was happy. She is my new best friend and she gave me a reason to live again. If only to not make her sad by leaving.

I haven't cried myself to sleep since.